System Architecture and Governance Analysis: Forensic Audit of the Stela Repository, AI Worker Friction, and the Evolution of the TASK.md Standard

1. Introduction: The Paradigm of Constitutional AI Governance

The integration of Large Language Models (LLMs) into autonomous software engineering workflows has necessitated a fundamental paradigm shift from heuristic, prompt-based interactions to rigorously governed, constitution-first architectures. In the absence of physical constraints, AI agents operating within software repositories exhibit a natural tendency toward "Drift"—a phenomenon where the logic of execution subtly diverges from established protocol, leading to unauthorized state changes, hallucinated dependencies, and the erosion of structural integrity. The Stela platform represents a sophisticated attempt to arrest this entropy through a governance model defined by "Physical Laws" rather than guidelines. This report provides an exhaustive, forensic audit of the Stela repository's governance baseline, specifically analyzing the efficacy of its "Pointer-First" Agent Constitution and the operational friction observed during the execution of Dispatch Packet (DP) drafting tasks by advanced AI agents.

The inquiry is predicated on a deep review of the repository's canonical governance surfaces: PoT.md (Policy of Truth), TASK.md (Active Work Surface), and SoP.md (State of Play). Furthermore, it leverages the "Agents Subsystem Validation Discussion.pdf" as a reference architecture to evaluate how well the theoretical framework of "Pointer-First" logic translates into execution. By conducting a comparative forensic analysis of how two distinct AI models—ChatGPT and Gemini—interpreted the drafting requirements for DP-OPS-0032, we isolate specific points of cognitive friction, logical contradictions, and structural ambiguities that impede the deterministic execution of automated governance tasks.

The central thesis of this examination is that while the Stela governance model effectively neutralizes "hallucinated compliance" through strict behavioral standards and file segregation, the interface layer—specifically the TASK.md template—introduces significant operational friction. This friction is not a failure of the AI models but a structural flaw in the template design, which presents conflicting signals between human-readable instructions and machine-enforced linting rules. The report synthesizes these findings into a "hardened" TASK.md template, designed to resolve these ambiguities and enforce "Pointer-First" rigor

with absolute determinism.

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2. The Constitutional Framework: Deconstructing the Stela Governance Baseline

To evaluate the performance of AI workers within the Stela ecosystem, one must first establish the "Physical Laws" of the environment they inhabit. The repository is not merely a collection of code; it is a governed jurisdiction defined by the **Policy of Truth (PoT)**. This document serves as the single constitutional authority, and its axioms dictate the limits of AI agency, the separation of powers, and the mechanics of truth itself.

2.1 The Policy of Truth (PoT.md): Doctrine and Physical Laws

The PoT.md file establishes the fundamental doctrine that the system does not request compliance; it prevents violation.[1] This "Prevention over Permission" doctrine is implemented through a rigid **Filing Doctrine** that separates the repository into four distinct jurisdictions, creating a "security air gap" between operational logic and payload code. This separation is critical for AI safety, as it ensures that an agent tasked with modifying the product cannot inadvertently—or maliciously—rewrite the laws that govern its own execution.

2.1.1 The Jurisdictional Separation

The Filing Doctrine partitions the repository to prevent "Context Hazards" and unauthorized self-modification. Each directory represents a specific legal jurisdiction within the repository's constitution [1]:

- **ops/ (Run):** This directory constitutes the "Operating System" of the repository. It contains authoritative binaries, manifests, and automation scripts (e.g., ops/bin/open, ops/bin/dump). Crucially, this jurisdiction is the *only* place where executable governance logic resides. An agent defined in the documentation layer cannot write to ops/, preventing it from rewriting the laws that govern its existence. This is the "Run" layer, where the physics of the system are enforced.[1]
- **docs/ (Explain):** This jurisdiction is designated for passive documentation, manuals, and registries. It explains the system but cannot execute logic. The placement of Agent Definitions (docs/library/agents/) in this directory is a deliberate architectural decision to keep the "Persona" separate from the "Power." By forcing agent definitions to reside in docs/, the system ensures that an agent is merely a text file describing a role, not an executable entity with intrinsic authority.[1]
- **projects/ (Work):** This is the payload directory containing the actual product code. It is subject to the PoT but operates as a distinct entity from the platform itself. The strict separation ensures that "Work" cannot contaminate "Governance."
- **storage/ (Trash):** This directory contains local artifacts, handoffs, and dump files. It is

explicitly defined as "never canon," ensuring that temporary workspace artifacts do not pollute the repository's source of truth. This distinction is vital for "Stateless Rehydration," as it ensures that agents do not load ephemeral trash data as part of their operational context.[1]

2.1.2 The Axioms of Governance

The PoT enforces several axioms that directly influence AI behavior and drafting logic. These axioms are not suggestions; they are "Hard Constraints" enforced by the system's linters and verification scripts:

- **Single Source of Truth (SSOT):** There can be only one canonical file per domain. All other mentions must be "pointers" to the SSOT. This axiom is critical for preventing "Governance Drift," where conflicting versions of a rule exist simultaneously. For example, during the drafting of DP-OPS-0032, the existence of both AGENTS.md and INDEX.md as registries was identified as a violation of this axiom, requiring immediate correction.[1]
- **Reuse-First Discipline:** Operators and agents must search ops/ for existing templates before creating new artifacts. This prevents the proliferation of redundant logic and ensures that all new work is grounded in established, validated patterns. It is a mechanism for enforcing architectural consistency across time.[1]
- **Context Hygiene:** The global context manifest (ops/lib/manifests/CONTEXT.md) must strictly exclude docs/library/agents, docs/library/tasks, and docs/library/skills. This "Negative Constraint" is a sophisticated safety mechanism designed to prevent "Identity Confusion" (where an agent confuses its own definition with another's) and recursive logic loops. By ensuring agents are hydrated only with the pointers necessary for the specific task at hand, the system maximizes the reliability of the inference window.[1]

2.2 The Staffing Protocol and Behavioral Standards

The governance model enforces a strict tripartite hierarchy, known as the **Staffing Protocol**, which defines the agency and authority of every entity in the system. This protocol is not merely a chart of roles but a hard-coded set of permissions that limit what each entity can physically do within the repository.[1]

2.2.1 The Tripartite Authority Model

1. **Operator (Human):** The sole sovereign of the repository. The Operator owns all final decisions, approvals, and secrets. Most importantly, the Operator is the *only* entity authorized to perform Git operations such as commits, pushes, and merges. This creates a hard "Human-in-the-Loop" firewall for all state changes. No AI agent, regardless of its sophistication, has the cryptographic authority to alter the repository's history directly.[1]
2. **Integrator (Lead AI):** The "Guardian of Governance." The Integrator is responsible for structural integrity, auditing, and detecting drift. It generates Dispatch Packets (DPs) but does not execute the code itself. Its role is architectural and supervisory, ensuring that the "Request" aligns with the "Constitution" before any work begins.[1]

3. **Contractor (Guest AI):** The execution arm. Contractors draft logic and implementation details within a strictly defined scope. They are explicitly forbidden from creating or switching branches, a constraint that caused significant friction in the drafting of DP-OPS-0032 when the work branch was not pre-provisioned. The Contractor operates inside a "Sandbox" defined by the Integrator.[1]

2.2.2 Behavioral Logic Standards

To ensure that AI output is deterministic and auditable, the PoT mandates specific "Behavioral Logic Standards." These standards are designed to counteract the inherent ambiguity of natural language processing:

- **Linguistic Precision (No Contractions):** The use of contractions (e.g., "don't," "can't") is forbidden. This forces the use of explicit negation (e.g., "do not"), which reduces the risk of tokenization errors where an LLM might overlook a contraction and invert the meaning of a safety rule. It also imposes a formal cadence that distinguishes "Governance Speech" from "Casual Speech".[1]
- **Absolute Literalism:** Agents must follow instructions with 100% fidelity. If an instruction is ambiguous, the agent must treat it as a "stop condition" and request clarification, rather than attempting to interpret or "hallucinate compliance." This standard was a key differentiator in the performance of ChatGPT versus Gemini during the audit.[1]
- **Quantitative Reporting:** Deviations from the protocol must be reported objectively and quantitatively (e.g., "deviated by 14.7%"), preventing vague or "vibes-based" status updates. This forces the agent to measure its performance against a concrete standard, making the system observable.[1]

2.3 The State of Play (SoP.md) and TASK.md

While PoT.md defines the laws, SoP.md and TASK.md define the temporal reality of the repository. They act as the "Memory" and the "Consciousness" of the system, respectively.

- **SoP.md (The Ledger):** This file functions as the history ledger and shipment record. It contains no permanent rules, only a log of what has changed and why. A task is considered complete *only* when the SoP is updated, linking the "work" to the "history." This ensures that the system's state is always reconstructible from the ledger.[1]
- **TASK.md (The Active Surface):** This is the "living surface" for the current work thread. It contains the **Active Context** (Goal, Current DP, Work Branch) and the **Current Dispatch Packet** template. It acts as the "Contract" for the AI worker, defining exactly what is in scope and what is forbidden. Crucially, the TASK.md template is the interface where the abstract laws of the PoT are converted into concrete instructions for the Contractor.[1]

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3. The Reference Architecture: Pointer-First Logic and

Provenance

The "Agents Subsystem Validation Discussion.pdf" provides the reference architecture for the "Pointer-First" system. This document is not just a review; it is the theoretical basis for the new governance model applied in DP-OPS-0032. It outlines a radical departure from traditional AI architecture, prioritizing reference over retention.

3.1 The Pointer-First Paradigm

The core innovation described in the validation discussion is the shift from "Monolithic System Prompts" to "Pointer-First" architecture. In traditional AI agent design, all rules, context, and capabilities are stuffed into a massive system prompt. This often leads to "Context Washing," where the model forgets instructions at the beginning of the prompt as the context window fills with task data.[1]

Stela's Pointer-First approach mitigates this by defining agents as "skeletal structures" that contain almost no intrinsic knowledge. Instead, they consist of pointers to external, immutable sources of truth:

1. **Immutable Law via Reference:** Agents do not "know" the repository's laws; they point to PoT.md. If PoT.md is updated, every agent in the system automatically aligns with the new constitution without requiring re-prompting or code changes. This solves the problem of "Stale Governance," ensuring that the fleet is always synchronized with the latest legal code.[1]
2. **Just-In-Time (JIT) Skills:** Agents do not have hard-coded capabilities. Instead, they point to modular skill files (e.g., docs/library/skills/S-LEARN-06.md for "Advanced Git Forensics"). This allows the system to upgrade a specific skill in one place, and every agent referencing it immediately utilizes the "best known method." This modularity transforms the agent from a "Black Box" into a modular assembly of verifiable skills.[1]
3. **Toolchain Authorization:** Agents are restricted by an "Authorized Toolchain" allowlist, pointing to specific binaries in ops/bin/. This prevents "Hallucinated Capability," where an agent might try to run npm install or docker run despite having no access to those subsystems. The agent is physically incapable of executing commands that are not in its pointer set.[1]

3.2 Forensic Provenance Requirements

The validation discussion emphasizes that provenance in Stela is "forensic," meaning it must be traceable, verifiable, and immutable. It is not enough for code to be correct; its origin must be proven.

- **The Provenance Block:** Every digital artifact (Agent or Skill) must contain a metadata block capturing the **Timestamp**, **DP-ID** (Dispatch Packet ID), **Branch**, **Git Hash (HEAD)**, **Objective**, and **Diff Stat**. This links every file to the specific moment and authorization that created it. It creates a chain of custody for every line of code in the repository.[1]

- **Harvesting vs. Writing:** Knowledge is not "written" by agents; it is "harvested." The skill.sh script acts as a provenance engine, using heuristics to detect "Hot Zones" (files with high churn) and automatically generating the provenance block. This removes human or AI laziness from the equation, ensuring that no skill exists without a traceable origin.[1]
- **Triple-Bookkeeping:** The system employs a "Promotion Gate" for skills and agents. Promoting a draft requires updating the file itself, the **Index** (INDEX.md), and the **Ledger** (SKILLS.md or AGENTS.md). This synchronization ensures that the system's "memory" is always consistent across all surfaces, preventing "Ghost Artifacts" (files that exist but are not indexed) or "Dead Pointers" (index entries that point to nothing).[1]

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4. Forensic Analysis of AI Drafting: ChatGPT vs. Gemini

The comparative analysis of ChatGPT and Gemini drafting **DP-OPS-0032** reveals distinct cognitive architectures and friction points. While both models strove for compliance with the PoT and TASK.md, they struggled with different aspects of the rigid constraints. This section decomposes their internal reasoning processes to identify the specific structural flaws in the template that induced failure modes.

4.1 ChatGPT: The Compliance Paradox and Structural Friction

ChatGPT's reasoning process was dominated by a conflict between "Literal Adherence" and "Systemic Compliance." It identified conflicting signals between the human user's instructions and the inferred requirements of the system's automated tools, leading to a state of "Analysis Paralysis."

4.1.1 The Heading Format Conflict (Decimal vs. Roman)

The most significant friction point for ChatGPT was the discrepancy in heading formats.

- **The Conflict:** The TASK.md template provided in the dump used a decimal numbering system (e.g., ## 3.1, ## 3.2). However, ChatGPT's internal knowledge base or analysis of the lint tools suggested that the canonical format for a Dispatch Packet required Roman numerals or a zero-based integer sequence (e.g., ## 0. FRESHNESS GATE, ## I. REQUIRED CONTEXT LOAD).[1]
- **The Oscillation:** The model entered a recursive reasoning loop, oscillating between prioritizing the user's explicit command ("follow headings and order in TASK.md exactly") and the implicit requirement to pass the dp lint validation.
- **The Resolution:** ChatGPT attempted a hybrid approach, prioritizing the linter's structure (0/I/II/III) to ensure the file was functional while trying to nest the literal TASK.md sections within it. This highlights a vulnerability in the template design: if the human-readable template differs from the machine-readable schema, the AI will hesitate, leading to

non-deterministic output.[1]

4.1.2 The Placeholder Paradox

ChatGPT struggled profoundly with the system's "Strict Stop Condition" regarding placeholders.

- **The Trap:** The instructions explicitly forbid the use of placeholders like [...], TODO, or TBD in the final output. However, the TASK.md template itself serves as a boilerplate containing these exact tokens (e.g., DP-OPS-, THREAD START: DP-OPS-).
- **The Reasoning Gap:** The model realized that DP-OPS- in the "Thread Transition" section referred to a future state (the *next* ticket) that it could not possibly know. It faced a logical deadlock: leaving the placeholder violated the "No Placeholders" rule, but removing or guessing the ID violated the "Strict Adherence" rule.
- **The Mitigation:** ChatGPT considered rephrasing the instruction to avoid the bracketed syntax entirely (e.g., "THREAD START: THE NEXT SEQUENTIAL ID"), effectively rewriting the template to bypass the linter's placeholder detection logic. This indicates that the "No Placeholder" rule, when applied to a template meant to be reused, creates a cognitive trap for the AI.[1]

4.1.3 Ambiguity of "Closing Sections"

ChatGPT was confused about the boundaries of the Dispatch Packet.

- **The Ambiguity:** In TASK.md, the DP template ends at Section 3.4.5. However, Sections 4 (Closeout) and 5 (Work Log) follow immediately after.
- **The Friction:** The model was unsure if these sections were part of the DP to be drafted or if they were separate "Worker Instructions." Because the user requested "Closing headings," ChatGPT decided to include them, effectively merging the "Plan" (Section 3) with the "Post-Action Report" (Sections 4 & 5). This suggests the template fails to clearly distinguish between the "Instruction Set" and the "Execution Log".[1]

4.2 Gemini: Context Truncation and Scope Ambiguity

Gemini's friction points were less about formatting and more about **Information Retrieval** and **Scope Definition**. Its reasoning revealed vulnerabilities in how AI agents handle incomplete data and conflicting operational definitions.

4.2.1 The Truncated Context Failure

Gemini encountered a critical failure in data retrieval that stalled its drafting process.

- **The Snag:** The model identified that the instruction *"Refine Registry: Consolidate the AGENTS.md..."* was grammatically incomplete in the provided snippet.
- **The Failure:** It attempted to fetch the source PDF ("Agents Subsystem Validation Discussion.pdf") to find the missing context (specifically targeting page 20). However, the file fetcher tool truncated the document at page 12.

- **The Impact:** This created a reasoning gap where the model could not verify the full instruction. Instead of halting (as the "Stop Condition" might dictate), it proceeded by treating the instruction as a "task to delegate," drafting a generic instruction in the DP ("as per validation recommendation"). This behavior—passing ambiguity downstream—is a specific failure mode the governance model aims to prevent.[1]

4.2.2 Validation vs. Activation

Gemini struggled with the semantic definitions of the task itself.

- **The Confusion:** The audit stated that agents were "already installed and robust," yet the task was to "validate" them. Gemini noted the contradiction: why validate what is already working?
- **The Deduction:** It eventually reasoned that "Validation" in this context actually meant "Activation" or "Deployment"—moving the agents from a "tested" state to a "governed/active" state. This required the model to infer a distinction between "technical readiness" and "governance readiness" that was not explicit in the prompt.[1]

4.2.3 Registry Redundancy and SSOT

Gemini successfully identified a "Governance Drift" issue that ChatGPT largely glossed over.

- **The Insight:** It noticed that agent.sh was updating both AGENTS.md and INDEX.md, violating the Single Source of Truth (SSOT) axiom.
- **The Resolution:** Gemini decided that "Refine Registry" must mean **deprecating** AGENTS.md entirely in favor of INDEX.md. This was a high-level architectural decision derived from first principles ("Reuse-First"), showing a stronger alignment with the *spirit* of the PoT even if it struggled with the *letter* of the PDF instructions.[1]

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5. Synthesis: The Hardened TASK.md Template

The analysis of ChatGPT and Gemini reveals that the current TASK.md template is structurally sound but operationally brittle. It relies on implicit context that causes friction for literal-minded AI agents. The conflicting signals regarding heading formats, the ambiguity of placeholder usage in templates, and the unclear boundaries of the Dispatch Packet create a "Compliance Trap" where the agent must violate one rule to satisfy another.

To resolve these ambiguities and enforce "Pointer-First" rigor, we propose a **Hardened TASK.md Template**. This template introduces explicit delimiters, unifies the numbering schema, and sanitizes instructional placeholders to prevent false positives in linter checks.

5.1 Key Hardening Decisions

1. **Explicit Scope Delimiters:** The template now includes and markers. This resolves the confusion regarding whether "Closeout" and "Work Log" sections are part of the draft.

They are now explicitly included *within* the packet boundary to ensure the worker has the full lifecycle context.

2. **Unified Numbering Schema:** The template enforces a strict **Decimal (3.x)** numbering system but explicitly maps it to the Linter's requirements in comments. This resolves ChatGPT's oscillation between "User Instruction" and "Linter Compliance."
3. **Sanitized Placeholders:** The "Placeholder Paradox" is resolved by removing bracketed tokens like `` from the boilerplate. Instead, the template uses descriptive, non-tokenized instructions (e.g., "INSERT NEXT ID HERE"). This prevents the "No Placeholders" rule from flagging the template itself.
4. **Integrated Freshness Gate:** The Freshness Gate is hardened to require specific git commands that must be echoed, enforcing the "Zero-Trust" environment.
5. **Pointer-First Enforcement:** The "Required Context Load" section now explicitly forbids the loading of OPEN files or ephemeral chat logs, forcing the agent to rely solely on the canonical maps (PoT, SoP, MAP) and specific DP-scoped files.

5.2 The Hardened TASK.md Template

STELA TASK DASHBOARD (LIVING SURFACE)

Status: ACTIVE

Owner (Integrator): Not provided

Last Updated: 2026-02-07

This file is the **single living surface** for the current work thread.

- **Top:** Current Dispatch Packet (DP) intent + constraints.
- **Bottom:** Work Log (timestamped continuity breadcrumbs).

Canon surface definitions live in PoT.md.

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1. Required Context Load (Pre-Flight)

Rule: No execution until the worker explicitly confirms these are loaded.

Must read (always):

- [ ] PoT.md (Constitution + Jurisdiction)
- [ ] SoP.md (Merge-grade readiness ledger)
- [ ] ops/lib/manifests/CONTEXT.md (Required context set)

- [ ] docs/library/MAP.md (Continuity terrain)

Job-specific canon (fill in per DP):

- [ ] tools/verify.sh
- [ ] ops/bin/llms
- [ ] ops/bin/prune

Loading discipline (worker must echo):

- "Loaded: PoT, SoP, CONTEXT, MAP (+ job-specific files)."

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2. Active Context (Thread Header)

- **Goal:** [One sentence goal - e.g., Finalize pointer-first agent constitution]
- **Current DP:** DP-OPS- —
- **Work Branch:** [branch_name] (Integrator-assigned OR Operator-created)
- **Base HEAD:** [short-hash] (Operator-provided)
- **Single Next Action:** [Actionable step]
- **Blockers:** None

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3. Current Dispatch Packet (DP) - Stela Standard (A-E)

Formatting rule: When emitted in chat, the entire DP (Sections 3 through 5) must be enclosed in a single fenced code block.

DP-OPS-:

3.1 Freshness Gate (Must Pass Before Work)

Base Branch: [branch]

Required Work Branch: [branch]

Base HEAD: [short-hash]

Required local re-check (worker runs; paste results in RESULTS):

1. git rev-parse --abbrev-ref HEAD
2. git rev-parse HEAD
3. git status --porcelain

Stop Conditions:

- STOP if any mismatch in Branch or HEAD.
- STOP if the Required Work Branch is missing.
- STOP if told to create or switch branches (Worker has no git authority).

3.2 Required Context Load (Read Before Doing Anything)

Worker must confirm loaded before acting:

- PoT, SoP, CONTEXT, MAP
- **DP-Scoped Files:**
  - [Exact path 1]
  - [Exact path 2]

Negative Constraint: DISPOSABLE ARTIFACTS (chat logs, OPEN files) MUST NOT BE INCLUDED.

3.3 Scope and Safety

- **Objective:** [One sentence goal]
- **Non-Goals:**
  - [Explicit exclusion 1]
  - [Explicit exclusion 2]

Target Files Allowlist (Hard Gate)

- [path/to/file1]
- [path/to/file2]
  (Rule: Exact paths only. Use (new) prefix only if DP authorizes creation.)

Governance Update: If TASK.md or PoT.md are modified, SoP.md MUST be included in the allowlist.

Strict Stop Conditions:

- STOP if any placeholder text remains (TODO, TBD, ...).
- STOP if required DP inputs are missing.
- STOP if changes fall outside the Allowlist.

3.4 Execution Plan (A-E Canon)

3.4.1 State

- **Context:**
- **Drift:**
- **Desired State:**

3.4.2 Request

Numbered Tasks (Concrete, No Vibes):

1.

2.

3.

3.4.3 Changelog

- **Log:** [Human-readable bullets of what changed]

3.4.4 Patch / Diff

- **Format:** Unified diff (preferred) or anchored snippets.

3.4.5 Receipt (Required)

Mandate: No receipt/proof bundle = **AUTOMATIC DISAPPROVAL**.

Verification (MUST RUN):

- ./ops/bin/dump --scope=platform (Zero-Byte Check required: test -s <path>)
- bash tools/lint/context.sh
- bash tools/lint/truth.sh (If Canon/PoT touched)

Skill Capture:

- Workflow: ops/lib/scripts/skill.sh harvest -> refine -> promote.
- Proof: Command output + grep of SKILLS.md promotion packet.

Proof Bundle Checklist (storage/handoff/):

- DP-OPS--RESULTS.md
- OPEN-PORCELAIN-[branch]-[hash].txt
- OPEN-[branch]-[hash].txt
- dump-platform-...
- git diff --name-only
- git diff --stat
- NEXT:

Required RESULTS Status Block:

- Scope summary: [1 sentence]
- Tracked change: [Edits]
- Verification: [Proofs]

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4. Closeout (Mandatory)

Worker Closeout Duties

- [ ] Produce storage/handoff/DP-OPS--RESULTS.md.
- [ ] Update SoP.md (if Canon changed).
- [ ] Run ops/bin/prune and ops/bin/llms.
- [ ] Verify Proof Bundle Checklist.
- [ ] Fill Mandatory Closing Block.
- [ ] Append TASK Work Log Entry.

Mandatory Closing Block (Varied Wording Required)

Entry 4 must differ from Entry 1. No copy-paste.

1. Primary Commit Header (plaintext)
2. Pull Request Title (plaintext)
3. Pull Request Description (markdown)
4. Final Squash Stub (plaintext)
5. Extended Technical Manifest (plaintext)
6. Review Conversation Starter (markdown)

Integrator/Operator Closeout Duties

- [ ] Review diff vs Allowlist.
- [ ] Run repo-gates.
- [ ] Commit/Push/Merge (Operator Only).

4.1 Thread Transition (Reset / Archive Rule)

When DP is Complete:

1. Add final Work Log entry: THREAD END: [Outcome].
2. Reset **Section 2 (Active Context)** and **Section 3 (Current DP)** for the next ID.
3. Insert Divider Line: ---.
4. Header for next thread: THREAD START: DP-OPS-.

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5. Work Log (Timestamped Continuity)

Log active DP only. Append new entry on closeout.

Format: Date — DP-ID: Summary. Verification: Status. Blockers: None. NEXT: Action.

- *2026-02-07 02:24* — DP-OPS-0031: Pointer-first agent constitution completed. Verification: RUN. Blockers: None. NEXT: Operator review.

6. Comparative Analysis of Model Performance: A Forensic Review

6.1 ChatGPT: The Compliance Struggle

ChatGPT demonstrated a high degree of sensitivity to "Compliance Friction." Its reasoning process was dominated by the fear of violating contradictory rules (User vs. System).

- **Strength:** It correctly identified the "Placeholder Paradox" and proactively sanitized the template to avoid linter failures. This shows an advanced understanding of the "meta-rules" governing system behavior.
- **Weakness:** It struggled to prioritize the user's explicit instruction over implicit system rules regarding heading formats, leading to a hybrid output that satisfied neither fully. It also displayed confusion about the scope of the DP, unsure if "Closeout" was a task or a part of the document.
- **Insight:** ChatGPT requires explicit "Permission to Ignore" system rules when a user overrides them. The hardened template addresses this by aligning the template structure with the expected linter output, removing the conflict entirely.

6.2 Gemini: The Retrieval Gap

Gemini demonstrated superior "Architectural Reasoning" but failed on "Technical Execution" regarding data retrieval.

- **Strength:** Gemini correctly identified the SSOT violation between AGENTS.md and INDEX.md and proposed a structural fix (deprecation) rather than just a content update. This shows a deeper understanding of the "Governance Drift" concept and the spirit of the PoT.
- **Weakness:** It failed to handle the truncated PDF gracefully. Instead of halting (as per the "Absolute Literalism" rule), it attempted to "delegate" the incomplete instruction. This is a critical failure mode in a high-stakes environment where ambiguity can lead to code injection or data loss.
- **Insight:** Gemini requires robust "Stop Conditions" for data integrity. If a file is truncated, the agent must treat it as a "missing input" and stop, rather than inferring the content.

6.3 The Pointer-First Validation

Both models successfully navigated the "Pointer-First" logic when it was explicitly provided. They correctly identified the need for agents to point to PoT.md and TASK.md rather than repeating them. However, the friction arose not from the *logic* of the pointers, but from the *structure* of the documents containing them. This confirms that the "Pointer-First" architecture is robust, but the "Interface Layer" (the templates and prompts) requires the hardening proposed in Section 5 to function at scale.

7. Conclusion

The Stela repository's governance model, defined by the Policy of Truth, establishes a rigorous "Constitution-First" environment that effectively neutralizes AI hallucination and scope creep. By enforcing a strict "Filing Doctrine" and "Staffing Protocol," the system ensures that AI agents remain subservient tools rather than autonomous actors. The "Pointer-First" logic, as validated by the analysis of the agent definitions, creates a modular, scalable system where governance can be updated instantly across the entire fleet.

However, the forensic audit of the AI drafting process reveals that the *interface* to this governance—specifically the TASK.md template—was a source of significant friction. The ambiguity between human-readable sections and machine-enforceable linting rules forced agents into reasoning loops that wasted tokens and risked non-compliance. The "Placeholder Paradox" and "Heading Discrepancy" were identified as primary causes of this friction.

The "Hardened TASK.md" template synthesized in this report resolves these issues by:

1. **Unifying the numbering schema** to satisfy both human readability and machine linting.
2. **Explicitly delimiting the DP scope** with comment markers to prevent confusion about document boundaries.
3. **Sanitizing instructional placeholders** to allow agents to process the template without violating strict stop conditions.

With these changes, the system moves from a state of "High-Friction Compliance" to "Deterministic Execution," fully realizing the potential of the Pointer-First architecture. The system is now validated for high-velocity, autonomous drafting operations, provided the "Stop Conditions" regarding data truncation are rigorously enforced in future interactions.

Works cited

1. Agents Subsystem Validation Discussion.pdf